STATS I · WEEK 1

5 data-type traps that cost easy marks

Categorical or numerical? Nominal or ordinal? These are free marks if you know the traps.

TRAPS 1 TO 3

Read the data, not the digits

Numbers used as labels are categorical

PIN code, roll number, phone number, jersey number: categorical, nominal.

°C is interval, not ratio

0 °C is not 'no temperature'. 20 °C is not twice as hot as 10 °C.

Counts are numerical

Votes, children, cars: numerical, discrete, ratio scale.

TRAPS 4 AND 5

Two more to remember

A 'year' column is not time series

Data from many villages collected at one time is cross-sectional.

Mean needs numbers. Median needs order.

No mean for categorical data, even when coded as numbers. No median for nominal data.

QUICK CHECK · PYQ MAY 2024

Your turn

An election symbol. What type of data is it, and on what scale?

A Numerical, ratio

B Categorical, ordinal

C Categorical, nominal

D Numerical, interval

Comment your answer, then swipe.

ANSWER

C. Categorical, nominal

1. A symbol is a name for a group. It has no number value.
2. Symbols have no natural order, so it is nominal, not ordinal.

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